

“gatekeeper”—if you want to see a specialist like a dermatologist or ophthalmologist. (Most HMOs, though, allow you to see in-network OB/GYNs without getting a referral.) Also, your choice of physicians is limited to your HMO’s network. If you prefer to see a specialist outside the network, you’ll usually have to foot the whole bill yourself, although most plans will let you apply for reimbursement afterward. The benefit of HMOs is their low cost: Most plans won’t make you pay any deductible, so your total cost per doctor’s visit is usually limited to your \$15 or \$20 co-payment.

With a newer, more common type of managed care plan, called a **preferred provider organization (PPO)**, you don’t need permission from your primary doctor in order to see a specialist in your network. But this freedom will cost you. Most PPOs require you to pay an out-of-pocket deductible, typically \$500 to \$600, before your coverage kicks in. (Many PPOs, however, do cover certain basic medical needs—like a routine checkup, an office visit when you’re sick, or prescription drugs—without forcing you to pay your deductible first. You’ll probably have a co-payment of about \$20 in this case.) PPOs also offer you the option of seeking treatment outside your network, but it will be more expensive than sticking to the list. Instead of the flat \$20 you’d pay for a visit inside the network, you’ll have to pay 30% to 35% of the total cost of your treatment up to an established maximum (usually \$2,000). But not all PPOs work this way. In fact, some require you to pick up 20% to 25% of the bill even for in-network doctors. So read carefully all the details your company gives you.

BEFORE YOU LEAVE YOUR JOB, ASK ABOUT YOUR HEALTH COVERAGE

If you work for an employer with twenty or more employees, in most cases your company must offer you the option of continuing your health coverage for 18 months—whether you’re fired or you quit. (Actually, if you’re fired for doing something truly heinous, like embezzling company funds, you probably won’t be eligible.) Under the Consolidated Omnibus Budget Reconciliation Act of 1985 (COBRA), your employer must offer you the same health insurance you had as an employee, but you’ll have to pay for the